

From “unpleasant” words to intensifiers in present-day Romanian

Raluca Brăescu, Adina Dragomirescu, Alexandru Nicolae,
Irina Nicula Paraschiv

“Iorgu Iordan – Alexandru Rosetti” Institute of Linguistics of the Romanian
Academy/University of Bucharest

raluca.braescu@unibuc.ro, adina.dragomirescu@unibuc.ro,
alexandru.nicolae@unibuc.ro, irina.paraschiv@unibuc.ro

Cite this paper: Brăescu, R., Dragomirescu, A., Nicolae, A., Nicula Paraschiv, I., 2024, “From “unpleasant” words to intensifiers in present-day Romanian”. *Romanian Studies Today*, VIII, p. X-Y.

Abstract

In this paper we analyse four patterns attested in present-day non-standard Romanian, in which originally “unpleasant” words, such as *rău* ‘bad(ly)’, *bombă* ‘bomb’, *belea* ‘trouble’, *în draci* lit. ‘in devils’, etc. come to be used as expressive intensifiers/superlative markers. All these patterns have in common morphosyntactic restrictions on the words involved and a certain degree of semantic bleaching: whereas certain intensifiers are restricted to words (particularly adjectives) expressing negative qualities, others lose their original negative meaning, being compatible with words expressing positive qualities. Our analysis is based on corpus study (on CoRoLa) and on a questionnaire we applied in November 2024.

Keywords: non-standard Romanian, intensifier, superlative, “unpleasant” words, semantic bleaching

1. Introduction

The **aim** of this paper is to analyse several Romanian constructions in which words originally having an “unpleasant” meaning (mainly a meaning related to negative qualities) come to be used as intensifiers or as lexical means of expressing the superlative without the negative meaning originally associated with them.

Although these constructions are mentioned in previous literature, there are several reasons for which an in-depth analysis of them is salutary:

(i) they have never been analysed together, and this raises the question of whether they make up a (semantic/syntactic) class; some of the patterns discussed in the preliminary inventory below even appear to be semi-grammaticalized strategies for superlative/elative marking (e.g., subclass B, see below);

(ii) a review of the reference literature has revealed that this type of semantic change (which has obvious grammatical reflexes) has not been previously comprehensively studied;

(iii) last but not least, the Romanian language shows certain characteristics which recommend it as a fertile ground for formulating and testing new ideas about semantic change and the syntax-semantics interface in language change: (a) the intensifier use of words which have a meaning related to negative qualities is systematic and relatively productive in Romanian (at least in certain registers); (b) while words with “unpleasant” meaning are known to function as intensifiers, there is a general semantic concord between the intensifier and the head to which it attaches (e.g., in English, *awfully pale*); however, in Romanian, negative meaning words may be juxtaposed as intensifiers to words with a positive connotation (e.g., Rom. *teribil de frumoasă*, which is literally ‘terribly of beautiful’, but has the interpretation ‘extremely beautiful’) – this testifies to the well-known inherent fuzziness of lexical semantics in natural languages (amply discussed in Hock and Joseph 2019: 189-222), and opens up new lines of inquiry about the relationship between the mechanisms of semantic change and their reflexes in grammar.

Our **objectives** are: (i) to briefly present previous research on the topic, conducted on Romanian or on other languages; (ii) to offer a classification of the patterns involving “unpleasant” words which specialized as intensifiers; (iii) to analyse four of these patterns (i.e. the ones specific to non-standard present-day Romanian) and the compatibility of these intensifiers with *positive* and *negative* words (adjectives, adverbs, verbs); (iv) to put forth a hypothesis that can account for this type of semantic change and to describe the semantic and cognitive processes that may lead to such a linguistic change.

Methodologically, our analysis is based on: (i) corpus study for the present-day language (mainly on CoRoLa <https://corola.racai.ro/>), in order to verify the frequency of the structures and their compatibility with positive words; (ii) the results of a questionnaire in which we aimed to verify the compatibility of certain patterns with adjectives expressing positive and negative qualities.

A note on the questionnaire

The questionnaire was applied via Google Forms between November 6 and November 15, 2024; we have registered 258 answers, from speakers belonging to different generations (as shown in Figure 1).

Vârsta
258 de răspunsuri

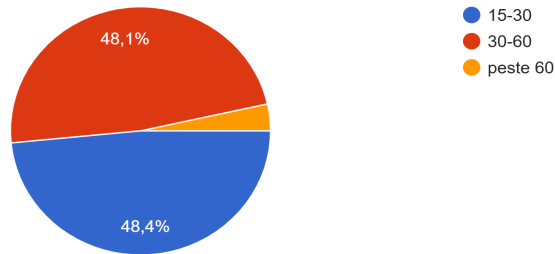


Figure 1.

Age of participants (48.4%: age 30-60, 48.1%: age 15-30, 3.5%: over 60)

As for gender, most of our respondents were women, as presented in Figure 2.

Sexul
258 de răspunsuri

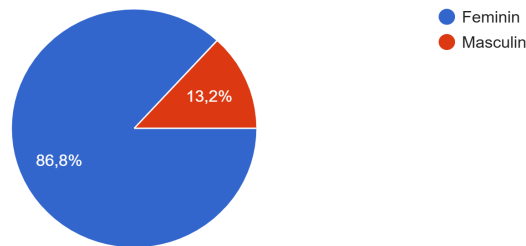


Figure 2.

Sex of participants (86.8%: women, 13.2%: men)

The speakers were requested to rate from 1 to 5 (1 = ungrammatical, unused; 5 = perfectly grammatical, currently used) ten sentences, belonging to different patterns discussed in this paper.

2. The state of the art

2.1. The Romanian bibliography and the general international literature on this topic are not very consistent, to our knowledge. The starting point is represented by Byck's (1967) study *Dezagreabilul ca mijloc de întărire* ['Unpleasant things as a means of intensification'], who first noticed and exemplified this type of change in Romanian.

Byck's hypothesis is that a pattern such as *amar de vreme* (bitter(NOUN) of time 'a lot of time') originates in *vreme amară* (time bitter.F 'a long time'), following another current pattern: *bunătate de om* (kindness of man 'a very kind man') < *om bun* ('kind man'). Besides some of the patterns included in our

classification below, Byck discusses other structures in which an “unpleasant” word becomes an intensifier, which we have excluded from our analysis since they are very rarely used in the present-day language, being now restricted to the literary register which imitates popular speech (1); however, the examples in (1) are interesting, since the originally “unpleasant” word is used as intensifier with adjectives having a negative meaning, such as *rău* ‘bad(ly)’ in (1a), but also with adjectives having a positive meaning, such as *frumoasă* ‘beautiful’ in (1b).

- (1) a. *mutul era rău nevoie mare*
 deaf.DEF was bad need big
 ‘the deaf person was very bad’
 b. *frumoasă nevoie mare*
 beautiful.F.SG need big
 ‘very beautiful’

Byck (1967: 111) explains such examples as a type of linguistic change, supported by the theory of contrast: displeasure can be a very intense feeling, which is reinterpreted by the speaker as a strength.

Certain patterns from our list above are mentioned in works devoted to the adjectival phrase in general, and to degree markers in particular: Pană Dindelegan (1992), Lüder (1996), Zafiu (2001, 2010/2023), Mihail (2009), the chapter on adjectives GBLR (2010/2016) and GR (2013).

2.2. As for the international literature, the only study devoted exclusively to this type of change, namely to the structure *to death* in English, is Margerie (2011); this English pattern corresponds roughly to our pattern in (E) below. Margerie (2011: 115) notices that the semantic change by which *to death* became an intensifier in the 20th century English is complicated: the evolution from a potential or actual result to a high degree meaning can be explained by an “interplay of metaphor, hyperbole and metonymic inferencing” (Margerie 2011: 115). As for the sources of this construction, the author suggests that it is represented by contexts displaying great semantic ambiguity (Margerie 2011: 115) and that the process, starting from the 17th century, was gradual (Margerie 2011: 119). Finally, we shall keep in mind the fact that, in present-day English, it collocates mostly with negative items in the construction (Margerie 2011: 130). Other English structures which can be mentioned here are *beautiful/gorgeous as hell*, *fine as heck*, attested on-line, but up to this point of our research we did not find any relevant literature on this topic; the literature on elative compounds generally discusses taboo elements, attested for example, in Dutch and English (Hoeksema 2012, 2023), but taboo elements (related to religion and superstition, sexual habits, and excrements) are not exactly the type we investigate here.

The most recent edition of the *World lexicon of grammaticalization* (2019) does not mention this type of semantic change; reference works such as Closs Traugott and Dasher (2001), Bybee (2015), Hock and Joseph (2019) or Hock (2021) do not mention or discuss this type of change either.

3. Classification

The words originally expressing negative qualities came to express intensifiers in several patterns.

(A) Lexical superlatives of certain adjectives and adverbs are expressed as adverbs or adverbialized nouns (*rău* ‘badly’, *foc* ‘fire’). They obligatorily follow the head adjective or adverb. This pattern is also mentioned in Byck’s (1967: 109). The intensifier *de mama focului* (2c) (of mother.DEF fire.GEN), discussed by Byck (1967: 109) and Lüder (1996: 152), is similar from a semantic point of view:

- (2) a. *frumoasă rău/ foc*
 beautiful.F badly fire
 ‘very beautiful’
- b. *Cântă bine rău.*
 (s)he sings well badly
 ‘(S)he is singing very well’
- c. *Ea este urâtă de mama focului.*
 she is ugly.F of mother.DEF fire.GEN
 ‘She is very ugly.’

(B) The second pattern is represented by lexical superlatives of certain adjectives and adverbs, whose structure consists of an adverbialized adjective with an originally negative meaning (*teribil*, *grozav*, *groaznic*, *îngrozitor* ‘terrible, awful, appalling’, *oribil* ‘horrible’, *cumplit* ‘cruel’, *monstruos* ‘monstruous’), the preposition *de* (‘of’) and the head adjective or adverb (3) (see Pană Dindelegan 1992: 73-97). The same pattern is also found with nouns in syntactic constructions where they are property-denoting (hence they are gradable) (4):

- (3) a. *teribil de frumoasă*
 terribly of beautiful.F
 ‘very beautiful’
- b. *îngrozitor de greu*
 awfully of hard
 ‘very hard’
- (4) *Mi-e îngrozitor/teribil de somn/frică/frig/cald*
 CL.DAT.1SG=is terribly of sleep/fear/cold/hot
 ‘I am very sleepy/scared/cold/hot’

(C) There are also intensifying nouns, having an originally negative meaning (5a-b); the pattern is also discussed in Byck (1967: 107), but in his examples the “unpleasant” noun expresses a high quality, not the intensity of a quality, as in (5c):

- (5) a. *o bestialitate de telefon*
 a bestiality of phone
 ‘a very good phone’

- b. *o scobitoare de fată*
a toothpick of girl
'a very thin girl'
- c. *o groază de parale*
a horror of money
'a lot of money'

(D) There are also structures in which the adjectival (6) or verbal (7) head is followed by a comparative phrase headed by *ca* ('as') embedding a word with a negative meaning. The interpretation of these constructions is superlative, not comparative:

- (6) a. *prost ca naiba*
stupid as heck
'very stupid'
- b. *urât ca dracu(l)*
ugly as devil.DEF
'very ugly'
- c. *sexy ca naiba*
sexy as heck
'very sexy'
- (7) *M-am* *plictisit* *ca naiba.*
CL.REFL=AUX.PERF.1SG get.bored.PTCP as heck
'I got very bored.'

(E) Certain result adjuncts originally expressing negative or bad situations turned into intensifiers. They may follow either adjectives or adverbs, as in (8), or verbs, as in (9). As mentioned by Zafiu (2001: 245-246), the pattern in (9) has been frequently attested with verbs ever since the 19th century, and it probably migrated to express intensity for adjectives and adverbs (8) (see also Lüder 1996: 169-174):

- (8) a. *plictisit* *de moarte*
bored to death
'very bored'
- b. *frumos* *de speriat*
beautiful of scare.SUP
'very beautiful'
- c. *enervantă* *de* *mă* *termină*
annoying.F that CL.ACC.1SG finish.IND.PRS.3SG
'very annoying'
- d. *urât să-ți* *bați* *părinții*
ugly so.that=CL.DAT.2SG beat.SUBJ.2SG parents.the
'very ugly'
- (9) *râzi* *de* *cazi pe jos*
laugh.IND.PRS.2SG so.that fall on down
'you are very amused'

(F) Certain intensifiers occur mainly with verbs: *la nebunie* ‘in craziness’ (see also Byck 1967: 109), *în neștire* ‘in ignorance’, *în disperare* ‘in desperation’, *în demență* ‘in dementia’, *în prostie* ‘in stupidity’, *în tâmpenie* ‘in stupidity’, *în/cu draci* ‘in/with devils’, *într-o veselie* ‘in a joy’ (see also Zafiu 2001: 246-249), *la mizerie* ‘at mess’, *cu spume* ‘with foams’, all meaning ‘a lot’.

- (10) a. *Îmi place la nebunie.*
CL.DAT.1SG like.IND.PRES.3SG at craziness
‘I like it a lot.’
- b. *Muncește în disperare.*
(s)he works in desperation
‘(S)he works unstoppably.’

Although all these constructions seem to follow a common semantic change path, they have a different register distribution: only type (B) productively occurs in the standard language, whereas the other ones are specific to the spoken language and sometimes even to slang.

In the following analysis we will only focus on the patterns specific to the spoken language (A), (C), (D), (F), excluding for now pattern (E), which will be the topic of a separate investigation.

3.1. *Intensifiers < adverbs or adverbialised nouns (frumoasă rău/foc ‘very beautiful’)*

The pattern in which intensity is expressed by the adverb *rău* ‘badly’ or by adverbialised nouns, such as *foc* ‘fire’ is not attested in the 16th and 17th centuries, but shortly after (Lüder 1996, SILR 2015: 96-97). The constructions under scrutiny (such as *fată frumoasă foc/bombă/belea* girl beautiful.F.SG fire/bomb/trouble) have been analysed before, from a lexical-semantic perspective by Lüder (1996), Stoichițoiu Ichim (2006), Szathmary (2012), or from the point of view of their morphological status by Barbu (2012), Farkas (2016), i.a.

Our corpus research on CoRoLa shows that the pattern has a high frequency in present-day Romanian. The example in (11a) is semantically close to the original meaning of *foc* (‘fire’) and can be considered one of the *switch contexts* (Heine 2002: 85), involving a mental comparison via conceptual metaphor (cf. Lakoff and Johnson 1980) (spice is like fire), whereas in (11b), *foc* is a verb intensifier. The contexts in (12) illustrate evaluative adjectives with a positive meaning: *simpatic* (‘cute’), *frumos* (‘beautiful’), *inteligent* (‘intelligent’); also, in the corpus: *cuminte* (‘wise’), *curios* (‘curious’), *deștept* (‘smart’), *drăguț* (‘cute’), *frumușică* (‘beautiful.DIMINUTIVE’), *harnic* (‘hard-working’), *îndrăgostită* (‘in love’), *scumpă* (‘dear’), whereas the ones in (13) show the availability of *foc* with adjectives denoting negative qualities: *supărat* (‘upset’), *furios* (‘furious’); also, in the corpus: *gelos* (‘jealous’), *zgârcit* (‘stingy’). From a semantic perspective, two phenomena are attested in these constructions: *semantic bleaching* (Eckardt 2006: 30) (the noun *foc* loses its original meaning and becomes a superlative marker) and *semantic elasticity* (Stoichițoiu-Ichim 2006: 244), i.e. once used as an intensifier, *foc* is compatible with adjectives expressing different, often contradictory, properties):

- (11) a. *gustul ardeiat foc și înecăcios*
 taste.DEF peppery fire and stifling
al unei lingurițe de muștar
 GEN a.GEN spoon.GEN of mustard
 ‘the very spicy and unpleasant taste of a teaspoon of mustard’
- b. *S-a supărat foc*
 CL.REFL=AUX.PERF.3SG upset.PTCP fire
și s-a izolat
 and CL.REFL=AUX.PERF.3SG isolate.PTCP
 ‘(S)he got very upset and (s)he isolated himself/herself.’
- (12) a. *Urșii, simpatici foc, parcă*
 bears.DEF cute.M.PL fire as.if
sunt niște babe
 be.IND.PRES.3PL some old.ladies
 ‘The bears, very cute, seem to be some old ladies’
- b. *Frumoși foc, plăcuți la abordare*
 beautiful.M.PL fire enjoyable.M.PL at approach
 ‘Very beautiful, very enjoyable to approach’
- c. *Gică era inteligent foc*
 Gică be.IMPF.3SG intelligent fire
 ‘Gică was very intelligent’
- (13) a. *Supărat foc, a plecat mai departe*
 upset fire AUX.PERF.3SG leave.PTCP more far
 ‘Very upset, he left far away’
- b. *sării din pat ca arsă, furioasă foc*
 jump.PST.1SG from bed as burned.F.SG furious.F.SG fire
că nu rezistase
 that not resist.PLUPF.3SG
 ‘I jumped out the bed as if lashed, very furious because she had not resisted’

The intensifier *rău* (‘badly’) frequently combines with verbs expressing actions with negative connotations, such as *a mușca* (‘bite’), *a zgâria* (‘scratch’), *a (se) supăra* (‘get upset’) (14a-c); also in the corpus: *a alunga* (‘chase away’), *a asuda* (‘sweat’), *a bate* (‘hit’), *a se complica* (‘complicate’), *a durea* (‘hurt’), *a se enerva* (‘get angry’), *a se îmbolnăvi* (‘get sick’), *a se întrista* (‘be sad’), *a se răni* (‘get hurt’), *a se scumpi* (‘become expensive’), *a sângera* (‘bleed’), *a se speria* (‘be scared’), *a se tulbura* (‘be disturbed’), *a umili* (‘humiliate’), etc. in the corpus. In these constructions, *rău* preserves its original meaning ‘bad, evil’. Its combination with other degree markers or approximators – *rău de tot*, *prea rău* (‘too bad’), *mai rău* (‘worse’), *foarte rău* (‘very badly’), *cam rău* (‘kind of bad’) – (14d-e) shows that *rău* is not (yet) grammaticalized as an intensifier.

- (14) a. *un câine care adulfmecă urme*
 a dog which sniff.IND.PRS.3SG traces
și mușcă rău
 and bite.IND.PRS.3SG badly
 ‘a dog which sniffs traces and bites badly’

- b. *se zgâriase rău de tot pe față*
CL.REFL scratch.PLUPF.3SG badly of all on face
‘he had scratched his face very badly’
- c. *L-am supărat rău pe profesor*
CL.ACC.M.3SG=AUX.PERF.1SG upset.PTCP badly DOM teacher
‘I got the teacher really upset’
- d. *Gestul lui l-a supărat rău de tot*
gesture.DEF his CL.ACC.M.3SG=AUX.PERF.3SG upset.PTCP
badly of all
‘His gesture got him really upset’
- e. *l-au bătut mai rău ca pe un deținut*
CL.ACC.M.3SG=AUX.PERF.3PL beat.PTCP more badly
than DOM a prisoner
‘they beat him worse than a prisoner’

As an intensifier, *rău* is attested in CoRoLa exclusively with adjectives denoting negative qualities: *speriat* (‘scared’), *jălnic* (‘miserable’), *frânt* (‘deadbeat’) in (15); also in the corpus: *amalgamat* (‘amalgamated’), *bolnav* (‘sick’), *cătrănit* (‘upset’), *deocheat* (‘exaggerated’), *nașparliu* (‘whacky’), *sucit* (‘whimsical’), etc. What this list shows is that the adjectives combining with *rău* belong to different registers of the language, from the standard language (*amalgamat* ‘amalgamated’, *bolnav* ‘sick’) to slang (*cătrănit* ‘peevisish’, *nașparliu* ‘whacky’, *sucit* ‘whimsical’).

- (15) a. *speriată rău de lătratul unui câine*
scared.F.SG badly of barking.DEF a.GEN dog
‘seriously scared by the barking of a dog’
- b. *Nu da’ sunteți execrabili, jalnici*
no but be.IND.PRS.2PL execrable.M.PL pitiful.M.PL
rău!
badly
‘But I sure know you are execrable, completely pitiful’
- c. *mergem la culcare, văd*
go.IND.PRS.1PL to sleep see.IND.PRS.1SG
că ești frânt rău
that be.IND.PRS.2SG tired badly
‘we are going to bed, I see that you are very tired’

The situation in CoRoLa was rather unexpected to us, but the absence of these constructions may be due to the fact that this reference corpus is mainly made up of standard texts. Therefore, we have searched in Google for *rău* in combination with adjectives denoting positive qualities: *bun* (‘good’), *frumos* (‘beautiful’), *deștept* (‘smart’). In (16) we show a few examples illustrating the compatibility of *rău* with positive adjectives; in (16d), the speaker shows an ironic attitude towards the person to which this sentence is addressed (see also the comments of the subjects of the questionnaire below).

- (16) a. *Un personaj bun rău* (gabiralea.ro)
a character good badly
'a very good character'
- b. *în orice caz, buni rău cartofii ăștia* (andie.ro)
in any case good.M.PL badly potatoes these
'in any case, these potatoes are very good'
- c. *Sunteți frumoși rău!* (digisport.ro)
be.IND.PRS.2PL beautiful.M.PL badly
'You are very beautiful!'
- d. *Dacă ești deșteaptă rău scrie*
if be.IND.PRS.2SG smart.F.SG badly write.IMP.2SG
tu rezolvarea (brainly.ro)
you solution.DEF
'If you are so smart, you should write down the solution'

Let us now proceed to the results of our questionnaire related to this pattern, recalling that the speakers were requested to rate the sentences from 1 to 5 (1 = ungrammatical, unused; 5 = perfectly grammatical, currently used).

The first four contexts in the questionnaire were related to the compatibility of the intensifiers *foc* ('fire') and *rău* ('badly') with adjectives denoting positive and negative qualities.

Sentence 1: *Fetița asta e frumoasă foc.*
little.girl.DEF this.F.SG is beautiful.F.SG fire
'This little girl is very beautiful.'

Fetița asta e frumoasă foc.
258 de răspunsuri

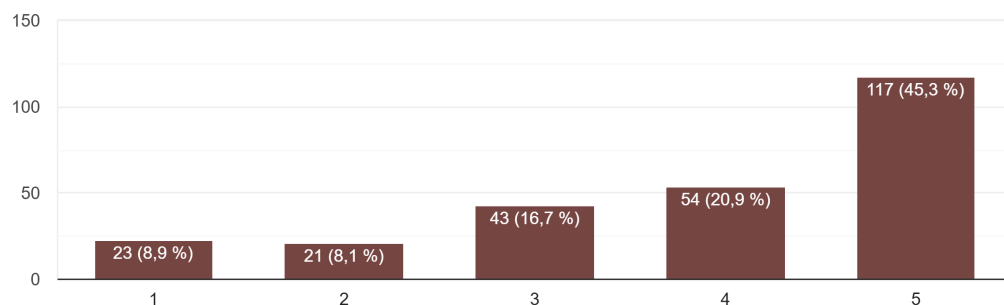


Figure 3

Sentence 2: *Fetița asta e urâtă foc, dar e foarte deșteaptă.*
little.girl.DEF this.F.SG is ugly.F.SG fire
but is very smart.F.SG
'This little girl is very ugly, but she is very smart.'

Fetița asta e urâtă foc, dar e foarte deșteaptă.

258 de răspunsuri

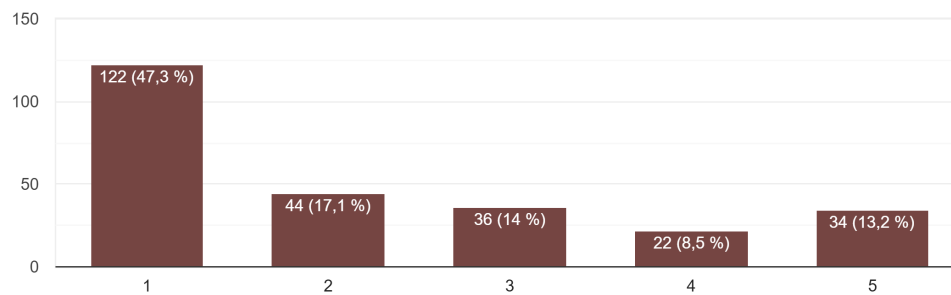


Figure 4

Figures 3 and 4 show that *foc* (‘fire’) as an intensifier is preferred with adjectives expressing positive qualities, but it is also accepted by a relevant number of speakers with adjective expressing negative qualities. In the observation section, certain respondents highlighted the fact that this is a construction specific to the spoken informal register and that they would not associate *foc* with negative qualities.

Sentence 3: *Prăjitura de ieri a fost bună rău.*
 cake.DEF of yesterday AUX.PERF.3SG been
 good.F.SG badly
 ‘The cake from yesterday was very good.’

Prăjitura de ieri a fost bună rău.

258 de răspunsuri

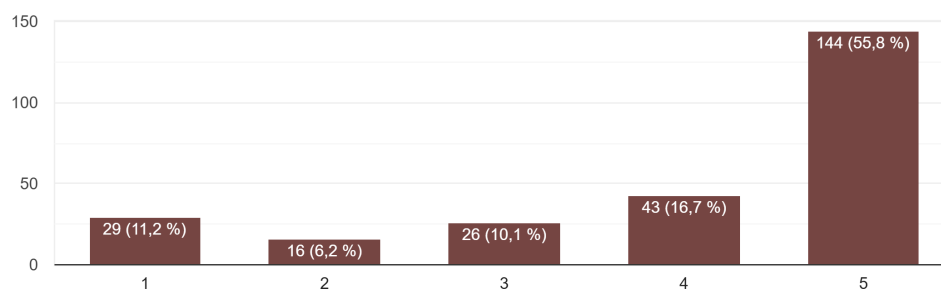


Figure 5

Sentence 4: *Am crezut că va fi foarte bună prăjitura asta, dar crema era acră rău.*
 AUX.PERF.1SG believe.PTCP that AUX.FUT.3SG be.INF very
 good.F.SG cake.DEF this but filling.DEF was sour badly
 ‘I thought that this cake would be very good, but the filling was very sour.’

Am crezut că va fi foarte bună prăjitura asta, dar crema era acră rău.

258 de răspunsuri

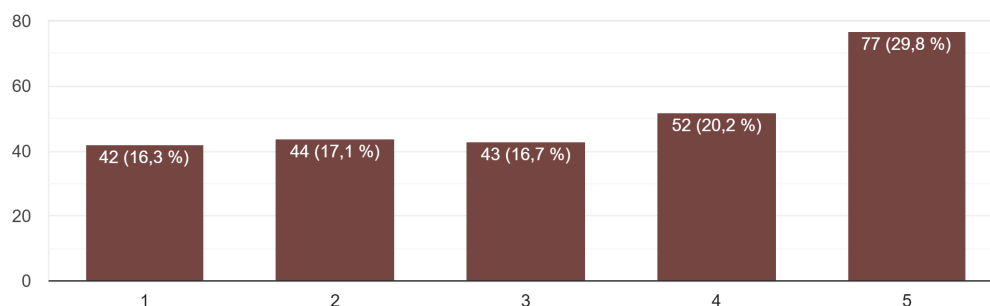


Figure 6

Figures 5 and 6 show that the intensifier *rău* ('badly') is almost equally accepted with adjectives expressing positive and negative qualities. Some respondents mentioned that *bună rău* is used only jokingly and with ironic value, whereas *acră rău* would be used without such an intention, with *rău* ('badly') as a synonym for *foarte* 'very'.

Therefore, although both express intensity, *foc* and *rău* do not function in the same way: *foc* is preferred with positive qualities, whereas *rău* is compatible both with both positive, and negative properties.

3.2. Intensifiers < nouns

In this section we discuss nouns such as *belea* ('trouble'), *bombă* ('bomb'), *bestialitate* ('bestiality'), *nebunie* ('craziness'), etc., which are used as intensifiers in the present-day spoken language.

The noun *belea* ('trouble, affliction') represents, in youth's language, a positive marker of superlative (*mașină belea* car trouble 'a very nice car'; *melodie prea belea* song too trouble 'a really good song'), although, etymologically, this word, borrowed from Turkish, has a negative connotation. Its semantic evolution is not unexpected: "In slang and colloquially, transitions between extremes are quite frequent, allowed by the affective value of evaluatives and by a general tendency – either antiphrastic or negativist and anarchist (what is bad is good) –, which exploits the unpleasant means as a reinforcing mechanism"¹ (Zafiu 2010: 106).

Similarly, the noun *bombă* ('bomb, bombshell') loses its original meaning and acquires an adjectival value, which also acquires a high intensity value (*femeie bombă* woman bomb 'very attractive woman', *știre bombă* news bomb 'very surprising news', *prețuri bombă* prices bomb 'very low prices', *o cursă bombă* a race bomb 'a very fast race'). Given the semantic transfer *negative* →

¹ "În limbajul popular-argotic sunt destul de frecvente trecerile între extreme, permise de valoarea afectivă a evaluativelor și de o mare generală tendință fie antiphrastică, fie negativistă și anarhistă (e bun ceea ce e rău), care exploatează resursele dezagreabilului ca mijloc de întărire" (*our translation*).

positive, both nouns can be used as positive intensifiers (sometimes in ironic contexts) in the pattern [noun (+ indefinite determiner) + *de* ‘on’ + noun]:

- (17) a. *o belea de mașină*
a trouble of car
‘a very beautiful car’
b. *beleaua de pisică*
trouble.DEF of cat
‘the very playful cat’
c. *o bombă de fată*
a bomb of girl
‘a very attractive girl’

The same pattern is represented by structures such as: *o bestialitate de telefon* (a bestiality of telephone ‘a very good phone’), *o nebunie de petrecere* (a madness of party ‘a very successful party’), *o scobitoare de fată* (a toothpick of girl ‘a very thin girl’). These constructions are made up of derived nouns expressing properties and they incorporate a positive superlative meaning (‘very beautiful, attractive, etc.’).

The high degree of cohesion is given by the presence of a sole linker, the preposition *de* ‘of’ and by the ordering restrictions: the sequence [noun + *de*] is obligatorily placed before the qualified noun and it does not allow interpolation.

In CoRoLa, the noun *belea* (‘trouble’) appears 523 times, but very rarely in the pattern discussed above, in which it acquires a positive superlative value; however, the pattern is attested in a few cases, in predicative contexts (18):

- (18) a. *Abia a intrat și el la facultate și acum*
just AUX.PERF.3SG enter.PTCP also he at faculty and now
își ia belea pe cap?
CL.DAT.3SG take.IND.PRS.3SG trouble on head
‘He has just enrolled in the faculty and he is getting into trouble!’
Hm, dar ce belea! Una care
hmm but what trouble one which
este-n stare să-l facă
is=able SUBJ=CL.ACC.M.3SG make.SUBJ.PRS.3SG
cel mai fericit bărbat din lume.
the most happy man in world
‘Oh, but what a trouble! One who is capable of making him the happiest man in the world!’
b. *August, era belea!*
August was trouble
‘August, it was amazing!’
c. *E de belea! E chiar ca-n filmu’*
is of trouble is really as=in movie.DEF
ăla panoramic...
that panoramic
‘It is great! It is exactly as in that panoramic movie...’

- d. *să fac un foc belea*
 SUBJ make.SUBJ.1SG a fire trouble
 ‘for me to make a very nice fire’

As far as the noun *bombă* (‘bomb’) is concerned, our corpus analysis shows that it can preserve its nominal category, with a new semantic value – positive – as in (19), it can function with an adjectival value, with the same positive semantic value, as in (20), and, moreover, it can combine with degree markers, as in (21):

- (19) *nouă bombă sexy a peisajului monden*
 new.F.SG bomb sexy GEN landscape modern
 ‘new sex bomb of the social landscape’
- (20) a. *titlu bombă*
 title bomb
 ‘a flabbergasting title’
- b. *anunț/ știre/ veste/ dezvăluiri bombă*
 announcement news news disclosures bomb
 ‘a surprising announcement/news/revelation’
- c. *piesă bombă*
 piece bomb
 ‘very good song’
- d. *prețuri bombă la mașini*
 prices bomb at cars
 ‘very good prices for cars’
- (21) a. *licoarea cea mai bombă*
 potion.DEF the more bomb
 ‘the strongest drink’
- b. *cel mai „bombă” sunet*
 the more bomb sound
 ‘the best sound’

3.3. Intensifiers < comparative preposition *ca* ‘as’ + noun

Comparative constructions used as intensifiers are attested in Romanian since the 16th century (Brăescu 2015). The preposition *ca* (‘as’) is used in old Romanian as an equative comparative operator (22), in contrast to its original value in Latin, where *quam* (‘than’) expressed inequality:

- (22) a. *ageri ca vântul* (A.1620: 21^v)
 fast.M.PL as wind.DEF
 ‘as fast as the wind’
- b. *veșmintele lui albe ca zăpada* (CC¹.1567: 211^v)
 clothes.PL.DEF his white.F.PL as snow.DEF
 ‘his clothes as white as snow’

The superlative value is frequent with stereotype comparisons (GALR I, 2008: 155), and particularly with chromatic adjectives: *negru ca abanosul* (‘as black as ebony’), *roșu ca sângele* (‘as red as blood’), *alb ca varul* (‘as white as

lime’), etc. These comparisons are relatively fixed combinations, belonging to the collective mind: they do not imply a quantitative degree information along one dimension, but rather associate two items on the basis of a similarity or analogy relationship, with respect to the stereotype.

The structures *ca naiba* (as Satan.DEF ‘as heck’), *ca dracu(l)* (‘as the devil’) are frequently used in the spoken language as intensifiers for negative properties (23), but they are sometimes used also with positive properties (24).

- (23) a. *drum periculos* ***ca naiba/*** ***ca dracu’***
road dangerous as heck as devil.DEF
‘a very dangerous road’
- b. *sos sărat/iute* ***ca naiba/*** ***ca dracu’***
sauce salty/spicy as heck as devil.DEF
‘a very salty/spicy sauce’
- c. *produs scump* ***ca naiba/*** ***ca dracu’***
product expensive as heck as devil.DEF
‘a very expensive product’
- d. *tricou colorat/pestriț* ***ca naiba/*** ***ca dracu’***
t-shirt colourful mottled as heck as devil.DEF
‘a very colourful/mottled t-shirt’
- (24) a. *delicios/ gustos* ***ca naiba***
delicious tasty as Satan.DEF
‘very delicious/tasty’
- b. *curioasă* ***ca naiba***
curious.F.SG as Satan.DEF
‘very curious’
- c. *sexy* ***ca naiba***
sexy as Satan.DEF
‘very sexy’

The structure of the phrase can be inverted, with the insertion of the preposition *de* (‘of’):

- (25) a. *un drum* ***ca dracu’*** *de periculos*
a road as devil of dangerous
‘a very dangerous road’
- b. *o fată* ***ca naiba*** *de sexy*
a girl as heck of sexy
‘a very sexy girl’

Although they seem to be quite frequent in the spoken language, these two structures are not attested at all in the written corpus CoRoLa. Therefore, we will directly present the results of our questionnaire.

Sentence 5: *Ciocolata de la tine a fost bună ca naiba, mai vreau.*
 chocolate.DEF from you AUX.PERF.3SG be.PTCP
 good.F.SG as heck more want.IND.PRES.1SG
 ‘The chocolate from you was very good, I want more.’

Ciocolata de la tine a fost bună ca naiba, mai vreau.

258 de răspunsuri

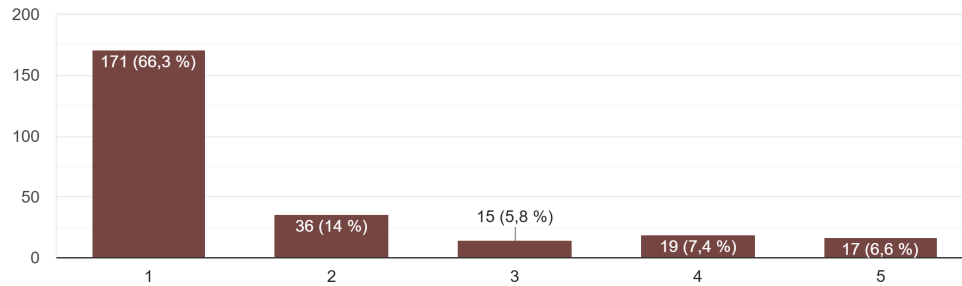


Figure 7

Sentence 6: *Ciocolata de la tine era amară ca naiba, să nu îmi mai aduci.*
 chocolate.DEF from you was bitter.F.SG as heck
 SUBJ not CL.DAT.1SG more bring.SUBJ.2SG
 ‘The chocolate from you was very bitter, please don’t bring me anymore.’

Ciocolata de la tine era amară ca naiba, să nu îmi mai aduci.

258 de răspunsuri

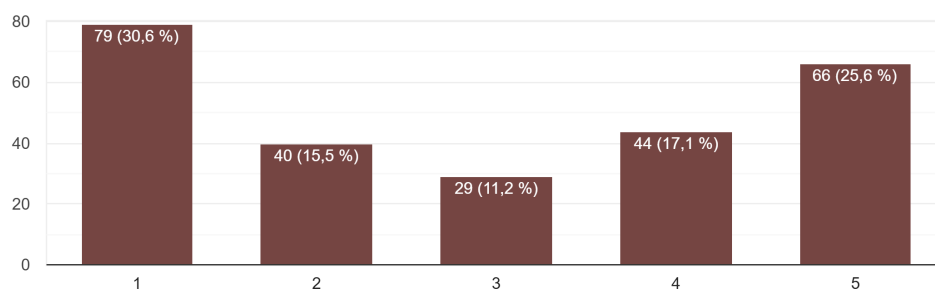


Figure 8

While Figure 7 shows that *ca naiba* is rejected by the majority of the speakers when it combines with adjectives expressing positive qualities, Figure 8 shows that the same intensifier is accepted with adjectives expressing negative qualities by approximately 50% of the speakers. Certain respondents noticed that *ca naiba* naturally associates with negative properties.

Sentence 7: *Eram îndrăgostit(ă) ca dracul, a fost cea mai frumoasă perioadă din viața mea.*
 was in.love(F) as devil AUX.PERF.3SG be.PTCP
 the more beautiful.F.SG period of life.DEF my
 ‘I was very in love, it was the most beautiful time of my life.’

Eram îndrăgostit(ă) ca dracul, a fost cea mai frumoasă perioadă din viața mea.

258 de răspunsuri

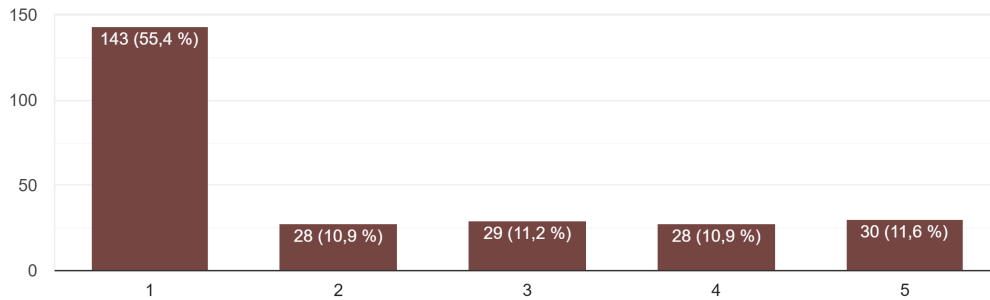


Figure 9

Sentence 8: *Eram supărat(ă) ca dracul, a fost o perioadă îngrozitoare.*
 was.IMPF.1SG upset(F.SG) as devil AUX.PERF.3SG
 be.PTCP a period awful
 ‘I was very upset, it was an awful time of my life.’

Eram supărat(ă) ca dracul, a fost o perioadă îngrozitoare.

258 de răspunsuri

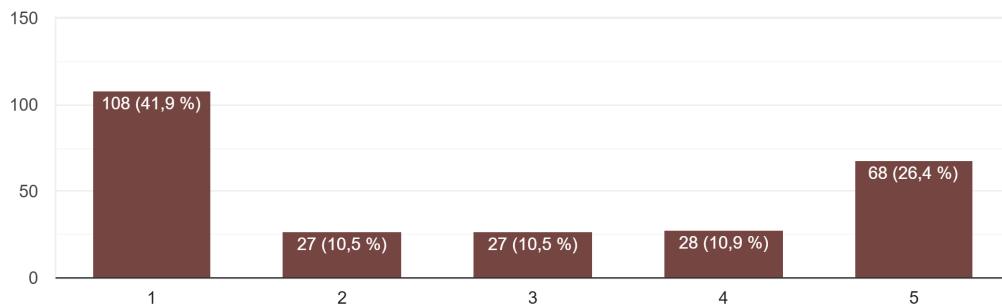


Figure 10

Figures 9 and 10 shows that *ca dracu(l)* is perceived by the speakers in the same way as *ca naiba*. In the same line of thought, some speakers mentioned that they do not use *ca dracu(l)* in positive contexts.

3.4. Intensifiers < preposition + noun

A very productive pattern in the present-day language is represented by constructions made up of the prepositions *în* ('in'), *cu* ('with') plus a noun, used as intensifiers. Our corpus survey on CoRoLa shows that the nouns occurring in these constructions lose their inflection and have a default singular form: *în demență* ('in dementia/craziness') (26), *în prostie* ('in stupidity') (27), *în neștire* ('in ignorance') (28) or a default plural form: *în draci* ('in devils') (29), *cu spume* ('with foams') (30):

- (26) a. *au încasat în demență cecuri din străinătate*
 AUX.PERF.3SG cash.PTCP in dementia checks from abroad
 'They cashed very many checks from abroad'
- b. *Ei omoară în demență, căzându-le*
 they kill.IND.PRES.3PL in dementia fell.GER=CL.DAT.M.3PL
victimă până și marele N. Iorga.
 victim even also great.DEF N. Iorga
 'They kill a lot of people, and even the great N. Iorga is their victim'
- (27) a. *dau like-uri în prostie*
 give.IND.PRS.1SG like.PL in stupidity
 'I hit the like button all the time'
- b. *transpirase în prostie*
 perspire.IND.PLUPF.3SG in stupidity
 '(s)he had perspired a lot'
- (28) a. *fuma și el în neștire*
 smoke.IND.IMPF.3SG and he in ignorance
 'he was smoking a lot'
- b. *am navigat în neștire pe internet*
 AUX.PERF.1SG surf.PTCP in ignorance on internet
 'I surfed the internet a lot'
- (29) a. *se publică în draci*
 CL.REFL.PASS publish.IND.PRS.3SG in devils
 'one publishes enormously'
- b. *vindea în draci abonamente*
 sell.IND. IMPF.3SG in devils subscription.PL
 'he was selling a lot of subscriptions'
- c. *muncești în draci!*
 work.IND.PRS.2SG in devils
 'you work enormously'
- (30) a. *urâte cu spume*
 ugly.F.PL with foams
 'extremely ugly'
- b. *căpoasă cu spume*
 stubborn.F.SG with foams
 'very stubborn'

These intensifiers have a rigid word order, being obligatorily placed after verbs ((26)-(29)), after (participial) adjectives ((30), (31)) or after postverbal nouns (32):

- (31) a. *era urâtă în draci*
 was ugly.F.SG in devils
 ‘she was very ugly’
- b. *culori deșirate în neștire*
 coloursspread.PTCP in ignorance
 ‘widely spread colours’
- c. *copacii înalți și subțiri filmați în neștire*
 trees.DEF high.PL and thin.PL filmed.PL in ignorance
 ‘the high thin trees continuously filmed’
- (32) a. *mâncarea proastă și mâncatul în prostie*
 food.DEF junk.F.SG and eating.DEF in stupidity
dau dependență
 give.IND.PRS.3PL dependency
 ‘junk food and overeating are addictive’
- b. *copierea în draci direct din carte*
 copy.DEF in devils directly from book
 ‘the massive copying straight from the book’

Of the structures discussed above, some are attested only in combination with verbs, nouns, and verbal adjectives (*în demență* ‘in dementia’, *în prostie* ‘in stupidity’, *în neștire* ‘in ignorance’), whereas *în draci* (‘in devils’) and *cu spume* (‘with foams’) are compatible with regular adjectives (see (30a), (31a)).

From a semantic point of view, the nouns occurring in these constructions are semantically bleached, the structure preposition + noun acquiring the value (‘a lot, extremely’) and expressing either a quantitative evaluation, neutral from the point of view of positive/negative qualities (*a cumpăra în prostie* ‘to buy a lot’, *a umbla în neștire* ‘to walk a lot’, *a construi în draci* ‘to build a lot’) or a negative evaluation (*a fura în draci* ‘to steal a lot’, *a bate în prostie* ‘to beat a lot’, *pătată/urâtă/trufașă în draci* ‘very smutty/ugly/haughty’). However, this pattern, similarly to the patterns above, also occur in structures with verbs having positive meanings (33a-d) or adjectives expressing positive qualities (33e-g):

- (33) a. *el tot o mai iubea în neștire*
 he still CL.ACC.F.3SG more love.IND.IMPF.3SG in ignorance
 ‘he was still loving her a lot’
- b. *inima-mi vibrează în neștire*
 heart.DEF=CL.POSS.DAT.1SG vibrate.IND.PRS.3SG in ignorance
 ‘my heart strongly vibrates’
- c. *guvidul trăgea în prostie*
 goby.DEF pull.IND.IMPF.3SG in stupidity
 ‘the goby was continuously taking the bait’
- d. *râdea în prostie*
 laugh.IND.IMPF.3SG in stupidity
 ‘(s)he was laughing continuously’

- e. *iubărești în draci*
 loving.PL in devils
 ‘very loving’
- f. *Este că-i bună în draci?*
 is that=is good.F.SG in devils
 ‘She is very good, isn’t she?’
- g. *optimist, jovial în draci*
 optimistic jovial in devils
 ‘very optimistic, jovial’

In our questionnaire, we have tested the intensifier *în draci* (‘in devils’) with an adjective expressing a positive quality (sentence 9) or a negative quality (sentence 10).

Sentence 9: *Actrița asta e frumoasă în draci,*
 actress.DEF this.F.SG is beautiful.F.SG in devils
sigur filmul va avea mare succes.
 sure movie.DEF AUX.FUT.3SG have.INF big success
 ‘This actress is very beautiful, the movie will be a big success for sure.’

Actrița asta e frumoasă în draci, sigur filmul va avea mare succes.
 258 de răspunsuri

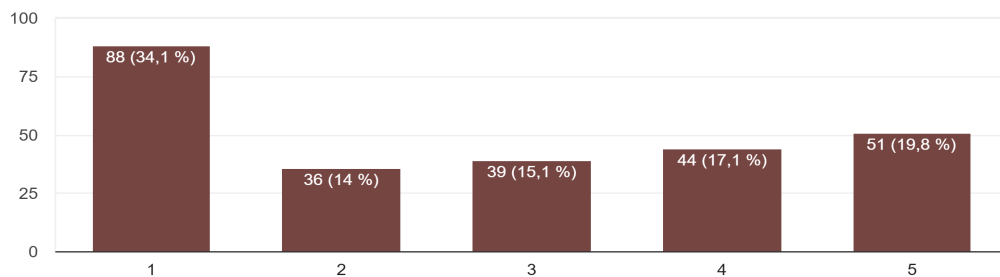


Figure 11

Sentence 10: *Actrița e urâtă în draci, n-o*
 actress.DEF is ugly in devils NEG=FUT
să se uite nimeni la film.
 SUBJ CL.REFL watch.SUBJ.PRS.3SG nobody at movie
 ‘The actress is very ugly, nobody is going to watch the movie.’

Actrița e urâtă în draci, n-o să se uite nimeni la film.

258 de răspunsuri

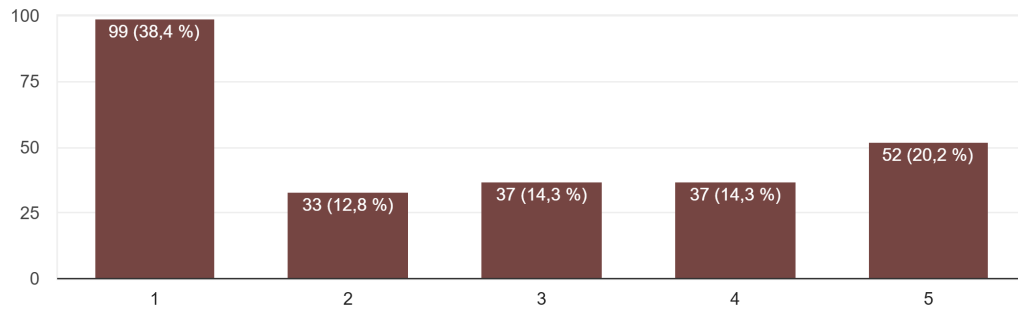


Figure 12

Figures 11 and 12 show that the speakers appreciate the combination of *în draci* both with adjective expressing positive qualities and with negative qualities as rather ungrammatical. However, around 35% of the respondents consider the structure to be possible irrespective of the semantic value of the adjective. The speakers do not express any preference related to the compatibility of the intensifier *în draci* with positive or negative properties.

4. Semantic restrictions of the intensifiers and concluding remarks

In this section, we investigate the behaviour of these intensifiers and we try to summarize, in Table 1 and below, the properties of the four patterns presented in this paper.

the intensifier	+ negative quality	+ positive quality	+ verbs	+ adjectives, adverbs	+ other degree markers
<i>rău</i> ‘badly’	+	+	+	+	+
<i>foc</i> ‘fire’	(–)	+	+	+	–
<i>belea</i> ‘trouble’	–	+	+	+	+
<i>bombă</i> ‘bomb’	+	+	–	+	+
<i>ca naiba/dracul</i> ‘as heck/devil’	+	(–)	+	+	–
<i>în draci</i> ‘in devils’	+	+	+	+	–
<i>cu spume</i> ‘with foams’	+	–	+	+	–

Table 1.

The properties of intensifiers originating in unpleasant words

As our corpus analysis and our questionnaire have shown, certain markers originating in “unpleasant” words seem to be compatible only with words having negative meanings, whereas others seem to have completely lost their meaning and are now compatible with words having positive meanings. What results from

our analysis is that the occurrence of these “unpleasant” intensifiers with words expressing positive qualities shows their higher degree of semantic bleaching and a more advanced stage on the way to grammaticalization, but none of our patterns can be considered grammaticalized.

However, our research suggest that the four constructions investigated here follow a coherent *semantic change* pattern.

(i) The point of departure is always an “unpleasant” word expressing an *intense* feeling and incorporating a semantic information related to intensity (see Pană Dindelegan 1992: 87).

(ii) The *intense negative feeling* can be conceptualized as a *strong feeling* (Byck 1967), a fact which explains why these words acquire an intensifying value in combination with other words expressing negative values.

(iii) At this point, the *switch context* (Heine 2002) is relevant: the intensity words are first used in contexts in which they are closed to their original meaning (for example, *ardeiat foc* spicy fire ‘very spicy’) and in many cases a *stereotype comparison* is at play (spicy is like fire, dangerous is like devil, etc.). At this time, the internal structure of the construction (adjective/adverb + intensifier) becomes relevant for the speaker.

(iv) In the next stage, the *semantic transfer* negative → positive occurs, with certain intensifiers undergoing *semantic bleaching* (Eckardt 2006) and becoming available with words expressing not only negative, but also positive qualities.

From a morphosyntactic perspective, in the description above, we have highlighted the fact that these intensifiers show *word order restrictions*, being obligatorily placed after the adjective, adverb, verb, etc.; the only exception is represented by example (25). Then most of these words show clear deviations from their prototypical behaviour: *foc* (‘fire’) changed its morphological class (noun > adverb), nouns such as *bombă* (‘bomb’), *belea* (‘trouble’), *prostie* (‘stupidity’), *demență* (‘dementia’), etc. are used only in their singular form as intensifiers, whereas *spume* (‘foams’) is used only in the plural. Moreover, some of these intensifiers are available only with verbs, whereas other can combine, as prototypical intensifiers, with adjectives and adverbs. Finally, some of these intensifiers are only by themselves markers on intensity, whereas others show the tendency to combine with other degree or approximation markers.

Corpus

A.1620 – *Alexandria*. Ed. F. Zgraon, București: Fundația Națională pentru Știință și Artă, 2005, 127–240 (*Cele mai vechi cărți populare în literatura română*, 11).

CC1.1567 – Coresi, *Tâlcul Evangheliilor*. Ed.: Coresi, *Tâlcul evangheliilor și molitvenic românesc*, ed. V. Drimba, București: Editura Academiei Române, 1998, 31–187.

CoRoLa – *Corpus computațional de referință pentru limba română contemporană*, <https://corola.racai.ro/>.

References

- Barbu, A.-M., 2012, “Construcțiile substantiv-substantiv. Atributul substantival în nominativ”, *Studii și cercetări lingvistice*, 2 (LXII), 153–170.
- Brăescu, R., 2015, *Gradarea în limba română. Perspectivă istorică și tipologică*. București, Editura Muzeul Literaturii Române.
- Bybee, J., 2015, *Language Change*. Cambridge, Cambridge University Press.

- Byck, J., 1967, “Dezagreabilul ca mijloc de întărire”, *Studii și articole*, București, Editura Științifică, 102–113.
- Closs Traugott, E., R. B. Dasher, 2001, *Regularity in Semantic Change*. Cambridge, Cambridge University Press.
- Eckardt, R., 2006, *Meaning Change in Grammaticalization. An Enquiry into Semantic Analysis*. Oxford, New York, Oxford University Press.
- Farkas, I.-Ă., 2016, “Superlativul absolut exprimat prin substantiv adverbializat”, *Studii și cercetări lingvistice*, 1 (LXVII), 121–137.
- GALR [2005] 2008 – V. Guțu Romalo (ed.), *Gramatica limbii române*, I. Cuvântul, II. *Enunțul*. București, Editura Academiei Române.
- GBLR 2010 – G. Pană Dindelegan (ed.), *Gramatica de bază a limbii române*. București, Univers Enciclopedic Gold.
- GR 2013 – G. Pană Dindelegan (ed.), *The Grammar of Romanian*. Oxford, Oxford University Press.
- Heine, B., 2002, “On the role of the context in grammaticalization”, în: I. Wischer, G. Diewald (ed.), *New Reflections on Grammaticalization*. Amsterdam/Philadelphia, Benjamins, 83–101.
- Hock, H., 2021, *Principles of Historical Linguistics*, 3rd edn. Berlin, De Gruyter Mouton.
- Hock, H., B. D. Joseph, 2019, *Language History, Language Change, and Language Relationship*, 3rd edn. Berlin, De Gruyter Mouton.
- Hoeksema, J., 2012, “Elativ compounds in Dutch: Properties and developments”, in: G. Oebel (ed.), *Crosslinguistic Comparison of Intensified Adjectives and Adverbs*. Hamburg, Verlag Dr. Kovač, 97–142.
- Hoeksema, J., 2023, “Elativ Compounds”, in: P. Ackema, S. Bendjaballah, E. Bonet, A. Fábregas (eds), *The Wiley Blackwell Companion to Morphology*. John Wiley & Sons. DOI: 10.1002/9781119693604.morphcom027.
- Kuteva, T., B. Heine, B. Hong, H. Long, H. Narrog, S. Rhee, 2019, *World Lexicon of Grammaticalization*, Second, extensively revised and updated edition. Cambridge, Cambridge University Press.
- Lakoff, G., M. Johnson, 1980, *Metaphors We Live By*. Chicago, IL: The University of Chicago.
- Lüder, E., 1996, *Procedee de gradație lingvistică*. Iași, Editura Universității „Al. I. Cuza”.
- Margerie, H., 2011, “Grammaticalising constructions: *to death* as a peripheral degree modifier”, *Folia Linguistica Historica*, 45, 115–147.
<https://doi.org/10.1515/flih.2011.005>
- Mihail, A.-M., 2009, “Tiparul sintactic afectiv (Det) N1 de N2: origine și realizări în limba română veche (*amărâtul de om, ceastă ticăloasă de țară*)”, în: R. Zafiu, B. Croitor, A.-M. Mihail (ed.), *Studii de gramatică. Omagiu Doamnei Profesoare Valeria Guțu Romalo*. București, Editura Universității din București, 125–134.
- Mîrzea Vasile, C., 2012/2015, “Adjectivul”, in: Gh. Chivu, G. Pană Dindelegan, A. Dragomirescu, I. Nedelcu, I. Nicula (ed.), *Studii de istorie a limbii române. Morfosintaxa românei literare în secolele al XIX-lea – al XX-lea (SILR)*, București, Editura Academiei Române, 63–110.
- Pană Dindelegan, G., 1992, *Sintaxă și semantică. Clase de cuvinte și forme gramaticale cu dublă natură*. București, Tipografia Universității din București.
- Stoichițoiu-Ichim, A., 2006, *Creativitate lexicală în româna actuală*. București, Editura Universității din București.
- Szathmary, M., 2012, “Forme de superlativ în limbajul presei românești actuale”, in: R. Zafiu, A. Dragomirescu, A. Nicolae (ed.), *Limba română: direcții actuale în cercetarea lingvistică*, Actele celui de-al 11-lea Colocviu Internațional al Departamentului de Lingvistică, II, București, Editura Universității din București, 283–289.

Zafiu, R., 2001. *Diversitate stilistică în româna actuală*. București, Editura Universității din București.

Zafiu, R., 2010/2023, *101 cuvinte argotice*, 1st edn./2nd edn. București, Humanitas.